Concern, Example, Impact: A Cheat Sheet for Sorting Family Care Problems

Nineteen words for the parts of a care problem, one plain line each, and what to write down.

"It isn't working" is one sentence covering a dozen different things. This sheet gives each of them a name, in one plain line, with what to write down about it.

The words are for sorting what your family already knows. They aren't for judging how your father is doing or how anyone is managing. A line with a number comes from a public source; the rest are the Family Care Roadmap's own working words.

The parts of a care problem

Concern

What someone in the family is worried about, in the words they used.

WRITE DOWN The sentence as it was said, and who said it.

Example

One specific thing that happened or didn't happen, with a day attached.

WRITE DOWN What, when, and who saw it. If there isn't one, write "no example yet."

Observation

Something you saw or heard yourself.

WRITE DOWN Only that: "The prescription wasn't picked up until Friday."

Interpretation

What someone thinks an observation means. It may be right. It is still a different thing from what was seen.

WRITE DOWN Keep it on its own line, marked as that person's view.

Impact on your father

How the concern touches his day: what didn't happen for him, or happened late.

WRITE DOWN What you saw happen, not a guess about his health.

Impact on the caregiver

What the concern asks of the person doing the work, in time, sleep or things of her own set aside.

WRITE DOWN What she tells you, in her words.

Differing accounts

Two people describing the same event differently. The Family Caregiver Alliance notes that parents often tell their children different things about how they're doing. [1]

WRITE DOWN Both versions, side by side, with who said each. No winner.

Related concerns

Concerns that are about the same thing, such as everything to do with appointments.

WRITE DOWN A short heading for the group, with its concerns under it.

Person to contact

Who should hear about a concern: the family, the doctor or nurse, the pharmacist, your care consultant, or not sure yet.

WRITE DOWN One name or role beside each concern. "Not sure" is allowed.

Next action and follow-up

The one next thing to be done about a concern, and who will check that it happened.

WRITE DOWN The action, a name, and a date to look again.

Open issue

A concern the family hasn't settled and isn't trying to settle in the next conversation. The Family Caregiver Alliance says it will probably be difficult to cover every issue in one meeting. [2]

WRITE DOWN The concern, and the date it went on the list.

Four kinds of problem

Care problem

Something your father depends on isn't happening, or isn't happening regularly. The National Institute on Aging's list of what caregivers help with includes bathing, preparing food, keeping track of medications and rides to appointments. [3]

WRITE DOWN The task, and the last time you know it was done.

Communication problem

People didn't know, weren't told, or heard different things. The task itself may be getting done.

WRITE DOWN Who needed to know, and what each person heard.

Paperwork problem

A form, a bill, a record or a signature that is stuck.

WRITE DOWN What the paper is, and who has it now.

Workload problem

Too much of the work sits with one person.

WRITE DOWN Who does what in a week, task by task.

People and permissions

Primary caregiver

The person who takes on most of the everyday caregiving responsibilities. It tends to be a spouse, or the child or sibling who lives closest. [4]

WRITE DOWN Her name, and what she handles in a week.

Hidden workload

The work the rest of the family doesn't see. Siblings may assume the caregiver has everything covered, the Family Caregiver Alliance says, and so not recognize the added responsibilities. [1]

WRITE DOWN The calls, the driving and the waiting, as she lists them.

Neutral facilitator

An outside person who helps a family that is divided on a big issue get through a meeting. The Family Caregiver Alliance says social workers, ministers, private case managers and physicians can do this, or refer the family to someone who can. [2]

WRITE DOWN Who the family already knows in one of those roles.

Consent form (HIPAA release)

The form most doctor's offices and hospitals have to specify who can have access to a person's private medical information. [5]

WRITE DOWN Whether your father has signed one, and whose names are on it.

What this sheet doesn't do

It gives you words for sorting. It doesn't say which concerns matter most, whether your father is safe, or what care he needs. That is for the people who assess him.

Ready for the next step?

You have a word for each part of a care problem and a note of what to write beside it. The care interview puts those words to work: it goes through your father's situation one area at a time and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving with Your Siblings
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
3. National Institute on Aging, Getting Started With Caregiving

4. National Institute on Aging, Sharing Caregiving Responsibilities
5. National Institute on Aging, Taking Someone to a Doctor's Appointment: Tips for Caregivers

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